

Info 590: Assignment #1

For my environment I chose to observe bookshelves. I chose bookshelves in two separate bookstores, the chain bookstore Barnes and Noble and the much smaller, local and independent Head House Books. Within those spaces I chose to specifically focus on bookshelves within those bookstores that were close to the entrance. I felt that choosing bookshelves that the stores had intentionally selected to serve as eye-catchers for people walking in was a fair comparison.

In both locations the items being organized within those bookshelves were physical books for sale. At both locations the organization of the bookshelves seemed to follow similar organizing principles, which I think is fairly common when working with books. As Glushko states “organizing principles are directives for the design or arrangement of a collection of resources” (2013, pp. 12). The bookshelf I observed at Barnes and Noble was first organized by the fact that all the books within that section were categorized as new arrivals. Then they were categorized by the fact that they all fell into the fiction genre, and after that were placed on the shelf by the author’s last name and first name. Interestingly enough, the bookshelf was arranged in a way where the end of the alphabet was closest to the door when you walked in, so for me it seemed like the organization was going backwards.

The Head House bookshelf was first organized based off the fact that these were the books that had been identified as having been the most sold within the bookstore. The books were then categorized by the author’s last name, and then first. However, there didn’t seem to be a distinction between fiction and nonfiction for this bookshelf. Other bookshelves within the store were separated by the category of genre.

Barnes and Noble was very obviously a very controlled system when it came to how the information within the section was organized. These were books that had been marked as new arrivals at the corporate level and were arranged by the predefined system that corporate had established for all of their chain stores for how to organize a bookshelf within

the store. There seemed to be no allowance for people working within the system to have any sort of impact on the organization of the bookshelf. Corporate decides what goes on that shelf and how, and that word seems to be law. In this sense, the organization system seemed to have limited ability to enable interaction as it seems mostly top down. The only thing that seemed to fall out of that system of controlled organization was the little tabs with a worker's comments about a book. My sister works at a Barnes and Noble location, so I know that practice is encouraged, but there is no structures rhyme or reason for who chooses which book to leave a personal comment on.

Looking specifically at the bestseller bookshelf at Head House Books, I would say the information was manipulated by the users. The fact that the books were listed in that section to begin with was solely based off the previous decisions of customers to purchase these books at a higher rate, thus directly influencing and manipulating what appears on the bookshelves in this section of the bookstore. The number of people working within the system i.e. the owners, workers, and customers did have an impact on the organization because it was primarily determined by how many people interacted with those specific books in that specific setting, and also by the fact that the owners and workers were actively capturing that data to shape the entire organization of that shelf. This seemed like an organization system where the arrangement of resources encouraged back and forth interactions between users and the collection (Glushko, 2013, Figure 1.1). In this case it seemed like all aspects of the bookshelf seemed to be organized, the bookstore just chose not to prioritize certain information buckets like genre.

As for how the information organization might be improved, it bothered me more than I expected that the shelves at Barnes and Noble were organized in descending order by last name as I walked in. It felt counter intuitive to the flow of the space. At Head House Books I was initially shocked about the fact that the books in the bestseller section weren't separated by genre, but I found myself actually liking that as it added to this feeling of serendipity when browsing the section.

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Reference

Glushko, R. J. (2013). *Discipline of Organizing: 4th Professional Edition*. University of California, Berkeley